

It won't be easy but the "frontline reformers" of the UPA Government see the six months before polls as a window to push big ideas. Fortunately, not all reforms are stuck in the legislative logjam (at last count, there were over 36 bills pending in Parliament at various stages). Indeed, there are administrative measures that the Government could push through like freeing domestic airlines to fly abroad, enabling minor disinvestment and pushing stalled projects like Arcelor Mittal and Posco, which are investing over Rs 1,25,000 crore in the country. Given the energy crisis, the Government would also like to look at opening up coal and coal bed methane blocks for private investment and extraction.

Even if they don't succeed in their initiatives, UPA ministers would like to signal a return to reforms or a right turn, so to speak, as a confidence-building measure. ■

of Karat's anti-imperialism, it seemed he was seriously suffering from c-deficiency ("c" as in conviction). All those days, he was prime minister but certainly not the prime mover of Indian politics. There was, of course, the Leader to take the decision, and he—the obedient, the dutiful, the diligent—was happy to be led, and shown the path marked by red flags. Perhaps he didn't have the freedom to resign. No deal was worth the displeasure of the Leader—or the comrades who sustained the Leadership. Finally he dared—and called Karat's bluff. He had an agenda and he was ready to die for it. "All I had asked our Left colleagues was: please allow us to go through the negotiating process and I will come to Parliament before operationalising the nuclear agreement. This simple courtesy which is essential for orderly functioning of any government worth the name, particularly with regard to the conduct of foreign policy, they were not willing to grant me. They wanted a veto over every single step of negotia-

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### The Insurance Regulation and Development Act

**Aim:** To enable foreign partners and/or foreign investors to contribute up to 49 per cent of the equity (up from current 26 per cent). This will enable access to more sources of capital for the insurance industry.

**Reality Check:** BJP assurance is now suspect and UPA will have to ensure support



### Comprehensive Framework for Licence for New Banks

**Aim:** The Government had earlier stated that new licences for banks would be considered only after 2009. This, though, requires a comprehensive framework on who can promote a bank. This may promote financial inclusion.

**Reality Check:** A new framework could be announced but action will only be taken post polls



tions, which is not acceptable. They wanted me to behave as their bonded slave," he told the House.

Like a politician who was worth his word—and who was fully in the game. It was his first vote of confidence as prime minister, and it legitimised him as a politician who can set the agenda. He so badly needed this legitimacy test. He is the chosen prime minister, not the elected prime minister. In a way, what happened on Tuesday was the most defining political test of his career. Beware, henceforth, the prime minister of India will be a political being. The prime minister-in-waiting was his obvious target: "(BJP leader L.K. Advani) has described me as the weakest prime minister, a *nikamma* PM, and of having devalued the office of PM. To fulfil his ambitions, he has made at least three attempts to topple our Government. But on each occasion his astrologers have misled him. This pattern, I am sure, will be repeated today. At his ripe old age (this is not Rahul Gandhi speaking but Manmohan who at 75 is only five years junior to his rival), I do not expect Shri Advani to change his thinking. But for his sake and India's sake, I urge him at least to change his astrologers so that he gets more accurate pre-